unsatisfying compromise.

For the moment, however, they held their peace, Tardi Beg and Abul Ma'ali, not to mention all the other equally authoritative, egoistic warlords who had marched across the Indus with Humayun. Akbar was able to claim his makeshift throne unopposed, uncontested – though not even the bricks he sat on were his. Akbar had inherited no kingdom – 'less than a petty district',[15] in fact. The Mughals had hardly been back in Hindustan a year, and barely held two cities, Lahore and Delhi. What Akbar had inherited was a conquest in progress, its future as uncertain as the course of a dream, and while his Khan Baba and Shamsuddin Ataka and Maham Anaka might console their charge for the death of his father, all of them must also have been fighting fears about the turns his fortune, and their own, could take.

The first of many such swerves in Akbar's destiny occurred within days.

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'This man was a dullard,' writes Badauni of Abul Ma'ali; he was 'drunk on old wine and read last year's calendar',[16] says Abul Fazl. Of all the late padishah's courtiers, Abul Ma'ali had most reason to long for the past. Humayun had favoured him but Akbar was guided by his bitter rival, Bairam Khan. Understandably wary, Abul Ma'ali did not attend Akbar's coronation. A message arrived afterwards, demanding his presence at a celebration some days later, but the 'self-conceited fool' replied he was still mourning Humayun's death.[17] No doubt he was. The last time he met Akbar, Abul Ma'ali had boasted of his place in Humayun's affections, of how they had drunk from the same cup, and complained that Akbar wasn't even inviting him to share his cushion. This time, would he be allowed to sit at all? Abul Ma'ali sent back word: 'how would His Majesty . . . behave to him, and where would he sit in the assembly . . .?' He would only come if he were seated on Akbar's right.[18]

It was agreed. Abul Ma'ali arrived and sat in pride of place; the banquet was laid out and the courtier held out his hands to wash. Immediately, one Tulak Khan Qauchin 'appeared on the scene like a spider's web',[19] grabbed Abul Ma'ali from behind, and put him in chains.

Bairam Khan was itching to execute him, but Akbar wouldn't agree. He didn't want to spill blood – least of all sayyid blood – so close to his